

MIKOMI

—— 日本語学院 ——

WHERE YOUR JAPANESE JOURNEY BEGINS

MIKOMI JAPANESE LANGUAGE INSTITUTE

JLPT N5

Grammar Handbook

ぶんぽう ハンドブック

40 GRAMMAR POINTS · 9 CHAPTERS

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Learn Japanese. Unlock Global Opportunities.

How to Use This Handbook はじめに

Grammar is the skeleton that holds a language together — and N5 grammar is wonderfully logical. This handbook breaks every essential point into a simple, repeatable shape so nothing feels overwhelming.

◆ How each grammar point is laid out

～例です *~rei desu*

the meaning appears here

Explanation — a clear, friendly description of what the grammar does and when to use it, written for someone seeing it for the very first time.

Formation: [the pattern to follow] + です

例文はここにあります。

Reibun wa koko ni arimasu.

Example sentences appear here — with romaji and English.

Tip: a handy memory aid or a common mistake to avoid.

PRACTICE A short question to test yourself → **answer**



Study advice. Don't just read — say the example sentences out loud and cover the answers to try the practice questions. Grammar sticks when you use it, not when you only recognise it. One chapter at a time is plenty.



9 gentle chapters take you from your very first sentence (「A は B です」) all the way to connecting your ideas with 'because' and 'but'. Each builds on the last — so work through them in order for the smoothest ride.

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01

The Basics

きほん

Your first sentences — how to say 'A is B', ask simple questions, and point at things.

In this chapter:

～は～です

～は～ではありません

～か

これ・それ・あれ

この・その・あの

～は～です *~wa ~desu*

A is B (statement)

This is the most basic Japanese sentence pattern. は (written 'ha' but pronounced 'wa' here) marks the topic — the thing you're talking about. です (desu) is a polite ending that works like 'is/am/are'. It makes any statement polite and complete.

Formation: [Topic] + は + [description] + です

私は学生です。

Watashi wa gakusei desu.

I am a student.

田中さんは先生です。

Tanaka-san wa sensei desu.

Mr. Tanaka is a teacher.

これは本です。

Kore wa hon desu.

This is a book.

Tip: は as a topic marker is ALWAYS pronounced 'wa', even though the same character is 'ha' elsewhere.

PRACTICE 私___日本人です。(I am Japanese.) → は

PRACTICE Make it polite: 'This is a pen.' これはペン___。 → です

～は～ではありません *~wa ~dewa arimasen*

A is not B (negative)

To say something is NOT the case, replace です with ではありません (dewa arimasen). In everyday speech this often becomes じゃありません (ja arimasen), which is slightly more casual but still polite.

Formation: [Topic] + は + [description] + ではありません／じゃありません

私は先生ではありません。

Watashi wa sensei dewa arimasen.

I am not a teacher.

これは水じゃありません。

Kore wa mizu ja arimasen.

This is not water.

田中さんは学生ではありません。

Tanaka-san wa gakusei dewa arimasen.

Mr. Tanaka is not a student.

Tip: ではありません (formal) = じゃありません (conversational). Both are polite and correct.

PRACTICE Make negative: 猫です → 猫___。 → ではありません／じゃありません

これ・それ・あれ *kore / sore / are*

this / that / that over there

Japanese has three 'pointing' words based on distance. これ (*kore*) = this, near the speaker. それ (*sore*) = that, near the listener. あれ (*are*) = that over there, far from both. They act as nouns ('this one').

Formation: これ／それ／あれ + は + ... + です

これは私の傘です。

Kore wa watashi no kasa desu.

This is my umbrella.

それは何ですか。

Sore wa nan desu ka.

What is that?

あれは駅です。

Are wa eki desu.

That over there is a station.

Tip: Think ko-so-a: KO near me, SO near you, A away from both.

PRACTICE Point to something far from both of you: ___は山です。 → あれ

この・その・あの *kono / sono / ano*

this / that / that ~ (+ noun)

While これ/それ/あれ stand alone, この/その/あの must be followed by a noun. この本 = 'this book', not just 'this'. Same ko-so-a distance rule applies.

Formation: この／その／あの + [noun]

この本は面白いです。

Kono hon wa omoshiroi desu.

This book is interesting.

その鞆は誰のですか。

Sono kaban wa dare no desu ka.

Whose is that bag?

あの人は先生です。

Ano hito wa sensei desu.

That person is a teacher.

Tip: これ = 'this one' (alone); この = 'this ___' (needs a noun after it).

PRACTICE ___ペンはmine (this pen). ___ペンは私のです。 → この

02

Essential Particles

じょし

The small words that glue Japanese together — they mark who does what to whom.

In this chapter:

～を

～に (time / destination)

～へ

～で (place / means)

～と (and / with)

～が (subject / but)

～の (possession / linking)

～も

～を *~wo (o)*

object marker

を marks the direct object — the thing an action is done to. It's written 'wo' but pronounced 'o'. If you eat sushi, sushi takes を. This particle is only ever used for this grammatical job.

Formation: [object] + を + [verb]

ご飯を食べます。
Gohan wo tabemasu.
I eat rice.

水を飲みます。
Mizu wo nomimasu.
I drink water.

本を読みます。
Hon wo yomimasu.
I read a book.

Tip: を is only used as this object marker — so whenever you see it, an action is happening to something.

PRACTICE 映画__見ます。(I watch a movie.) → を

～に (time / destination) *~ni*

at (time) / to (place)

に is a versatile particle. Two key N5 uses: (1) marking a specific time — 7時に (at 7 o'clock); (2) marking a destination or goal with movement verbs — 学校に行きます (go TO school). Think of に as pinning down an exact point.

Formation: [time] + に / [destination] + に + [movement verb]

七時に起きます。
Shichiji ni okimasu.
I get up at seven.

学校に行きます。
Gakkou ni ikimasu.
I go to school.

日本に来ました。
Nihon ni kimashita.
I came to Japan.

Tip: Use に for exact clock times. Vague time words like 今日 (today) don't take に.

PRACTICE 九時__会いましょう。(Let's meet at nine.) → に

PRACTICE 駅__行きます。(I go to the station.) → に

～で (place / means) ~de

at/in (place of action) / by (means)

で has two main N5 uses: (1) the place where an action happens — レストランで食べます (eat AT a restaurant); (2) the means or tool — バスで行きます (go BY bus). Don't confuse place-で (action location) with に (destination).

Formation: [place] + で + [action] / [means] + で + [verb]

図書館で勉強します。

Toshokan de benkyou shimasu.

I study at the library.

電車で行きます。

Densha de ikimasu.

I go by train.

箸で食べます。

Hashi de tabemasu.

I eat with chopsticks.

Tip: で = where the action happens; に = where you're going. 学校で勉強 (study at school) vs 学校に行く (go to school).

PRACTICE うち___映画を見ます。(I watch a movie at home.) → で

PRACTICE ペン___書きます。(I write with a pen.) → で

～と (and / with) ~to

and (nouns) / with (someone)

と joins nouns together ('A and B') and also means 'with' a person. It only connects nouns — never sentences or verbs. パンとたまご = bread and eggs; 友達と = with a friend.

Formation: [noun] + と + [noun] / [person] + と

パンと牛乳を買います。

Pan to gyuunyuu wo kaimasu.

I buy bread and milk.

友達と映画を見ます。

Tomodachi to eiga wo mimasu.

I watch a movie with a friend.

犬と猫がいます。

Inu to neko ga imasu.

There are a dog and a cat.

Tip: と connects nouns only. For 'and' between sentences, you'll use other words later.

PRACTICE 肉___野菜 (meat and vegetables) → と

PRACTICE 家族___旅行します。(I travel with my family.) → と

～の (possession / linking) ~no

's / of

の links two nouns, most often showing possession: 私の本 = my book (literally 'I's book'). It also connects related nouns like 日本語の先生 = Japanese[-language] teacher. The order is owner + の + thing.

Formation: [owner/descriptor] + の + [noun]

これは私の車です。

Kore wa watashi no kuruma desu.

This is my car.

日本語の本を読みます。

Nihongo no hon wo yomimasu.

I read a Japanese book.

田中さんの鞆です。

Tanaka-san no kaban desu.

It's Mr. Tanaka's bag.

Tip: の works backwards from English: 'my book' = 私の本 (me-of-book).

PRACTICE 私__友達 (my friend) → の

PRACTICE Whose bag? → 誰__鞆ですか。 → の

～も ~mo

also / too

も means 'also' or 'too', and it REPLACES は, が, or を (not added alongside them). 私も = me too. When used with a negative, it means 'not... either'.

Formation: [noun] + も (replacing は/が/を)

私も学生です。

Watashi mo gakusei desu.

I am also a student.

これもください。

Kore mo kudasai.

This one too, please.

お茶もコーヒーも好きです。

Ocha mo koohii mo suki desu.

I like both tea and coffee.

Tip: も kicks out は/が/を – say 私も, never 私はも.

PRACTICE You're a student too: あなた__学生です。 → も

03

Verbs — Polite Form

どうし

How to talk about actions politely: doing, not doing, did, and didn't.

In this chapter:

～ます

～ません

～ました

～ませんでした

～ましょう

～ませんか

～ます *~masu*

polite present/future verb

The ます-form is the polite way to end a verb. It covers both present habits and future plans — 食べます can mean 'I eat' or 'I will eat', depending on context. This is the safest, most respectful verb form for beginners to use everywhere.

Formation: [verb stem] + ます

毎日勉強します。

Mainichi benkyou shimasu.

I study every day.

明日行きます。

Ashita ikimasu.

I will go tomorrow.

お茶を飲みます。

Ocha wo nomimasu.

I drink tea.

Tip: ます-form is both 'do' and 'will do' — Japanese doesn't separate present and future here.

PRACTICE Politely: 'I read.' 本を読み___. → ます

～ません *~masen*

polite negative verb

To make a polite verb negative ('do not / will not'), change ます to ません. 食べます (eat) → 食べません (do not eat). Simple and consistent for every verb.

Formation: [verb stem] + ません

肉を食べません。

Niku wo tabemasen.

I don't eat meat.

今日は行きません。

Kyou wa ikimasen.

I won't go today.

お酒を飲みません。

Osake wo nomimasen.

I don't drink alcohol.

Tip: Just swap the ending: ます → ません. Nothing else changes.

PRACTICE Negative: わかります → わかり___. → ません

～ました *~mashita*

polite past verb

～ませんでした *~masen deshita*

polite past negative verb

For something that did NOT happen, use ませんでした. 食べます → 食べませんでした (did not eat). It's simply the negative ません plus でした for the past.

Formation: [verb stem] + ませんでした

昨日勉強しませんでした。
Kinou benkyou shimasen deshita.
I didn't study yesterday.

何も食べませんでした。
Nani mo tabemasen deshita.
I didn't eat anything.

彼は来ませんでした。
Kare wa kimasen deshita.
He didn't come.

Tip: Build it in two pieces: ません (negative) + でした (past) = 'did not'.

PRACTICE Past negative: 行きます → 行き____。 → ませんでした

～ましょう *~mashou*

let's ~ / shall we ~

To suggest doing something together ('let's...'), change ます to ましょう. Adding か makes it a softer invitation: 行きましょうか (shall we go?).

Formation: [verb stem] + ましょう (か)

一緒に行きましょう。
Issho ni ikimashou.
Let's go together.

お茶を飲みましょう。
Ocha wo nomimashou.
Let's drink tea.

始めましょうか。
Hajimemashou ka.
Shall we begin?

Tip: ましょう = 'let's'; ましょうか = 'shall we?' (a gentler offer).

PRACTICE Let's eat: 食べ____。 → ましょう

～ませんか *~masen ka*

won't you ~? (invitation)

A polite way to invite someone is the negative question ませんか — literally 'won't you...?', but it's a warm invitation, not a real negative. 食べませんか。Would you like to eat?

04

i-Adjectives

けいようし

Describing words that end in い — how they work in the present, past, and negative.

In this chapter:

i-adjective + です

i-adjective negative (～くない)

i-adjective past (～かった)

i-adjective + noun

i-adjective + です *~i desu*

is [adjective] (present)

i-adjectives end in い and can directly describe or sit before です. 高いです = 'is expensive'. Unlike English, the adjective itself carries the meaning; です just adds politeness. Don't insert anything between the adjective and です.

Formation: [i-adjective] + です

この本は高いです。
Kono hon wa takai desu.
 This book is expensive.

今日は暑いです。
Kyou wa atsui desu.
 Today is hot.

富士山は高いです。
Fujisan wa takai desu.
 Mt. Fuji is tall.

Tip: Keep the い: 高いです, never 高くです. です is just politeness here.

PRACTICE 'The cat is cute.' 猫はかわい___です。 → い

i-adjective negative (〜くない) *~kunai*

is not [adjective]

To make an i-adjective negative, drop the final い and add くない. 高い → 高くない (not expensive). Add です for politeness: 高くないです. One irregular: いい (good) becomes よくない.

Formation: [i-adj minus い] + くない + です

この店は高くないです。
Kono mise wa takakunai desu.
 This shop is not expensive.

今日は寒くないです。
Kyou wa samukunai desu.
 Today is not cold.

この映画は良くないです。
Kono eiga wa yokunai desu.
 This movie is not good.

Tip: Watch the irregular: いい (good) → よくない, never いくない.

PRACTICE 'not hot' 暑い → 暑___です。 → くない

i-adjective past (〜かった) *~katta*

was [adjective]

For the past tense of an i-adjective, drop the final い and add かった. 高い → 高かった (was expensive). 暑かったです.

i-adjective + noun ~i + noun**[adjective] [noun]**

To put an i-adjective directly before a noun (like 'a big house'), just place it in front — no particle needed. 大きい家 = big house. The い stays.

Formation: [i-adjective] + [noun]

大きい家に住んでいます。

Ookii ie ni sunde imasu.

I live in a big house.

新しい車を買いました。

Atarashii kuruma wo kaimashita.

I bought a new car.

面白い本を読みます。

Omoshiroi hon wo yomimasu.

I read an interesting book.

Tip: No particle between adjective and noun: 高い山 (tall mountain), not 高いの山.

PRACTICE 'a cute cat' → __猫 (use かわいい) → かわいい



05

na-Adjectives

けいようどうし

The other kind of adjective — these need な before a noun and behave a little differently.

WHERE YOUR JAPANESE JOURNEY BEGINS

In this chapter:

na-adjective + です

na-adjective + noun

na-adjective negative

na-adjective + です ~na-adj desu

is [adjective] (present)

na-adjectives don't end in い (or are exceptions like きれい). With です they behave like nouns: 静かです = 'is quiet'. No な is used before です — only before a noun.

Formation: [na-adjective] + です

この部屋は静かです。
Kono heya wa shizuka desu.
 This room is quiet.

彼女は元気です。
Kanojo wa genki desu.
 She is well.

この街はきれいです。
Kono machi wa kirei desu.
 This town is pretty.

Tip: きれい and 嫌い end in い but are na-adjectives — don't be fooled!

PRACTICE 'is convenient' 便利 → 便利___. → です

na-adjective + noun ~na + noun

[adjective] [noun]

To place a na-adjective before a noun, insert な between them. 静かな部屋 = a quiet room. This な is the reason they're called na-adjectives.

Formation: [na-adjective] + な + [noun]

静かな部屋が好きです。
Shizuka na heya ga suki desu.
 I like quiet rooms.

有名な人に会いました。
Yuumei na hito ni aimashita.
 I met a famous person.

きれいな花ですね。
Kirei na hana desu ne.
 It's a pretty flower, isn't it?

Tip: na-adjective + な + noun. The な only appears before a noun, not before です.

PRACTICE 'a famous shop' → 有名___店 (use 有名) → な

na-adjective negative ~dewa arimasen

is not [adjective]

na-adjectives go negative just like nouns: add ではありません (or じゃありません). 静かではありません = is

06

Existence & Location

そんざい

How to say something 'is there' — with different verbs for living and non-living things.

WHERE YOUR JAPANESE JOURNEY BEGINS

In this chapter: あります います 位置の言葉 (上・下・中…)

あります *arimasu***there is (non-living things)**

あります expresses the existence of non-living things — objects, plants, events. Use が to mark what exists. 本があります = there is a book. The location takes に.

Formation: [place] に [thing] があります

机の上に本があります。

Tsukue no ue ni hon ga arimasu.

There is a book on the desk.

お金がありません。

Okane ga arimasen.

I have no money.

明日試験があります。

Ashita shiken ga arimasu.

There is an exam tomorrow.

Tip: あります is for things, plants, and events — anything that doesn't move on its own.**PRACTICE** 'There is a pen.' ペン___あります。 → が**います** *imasu***there is (living things)**

います expresses the existence of living, moving things — people and animals. 猫がいます = there is a cat. Same structure as あります, just for living beings.

Formation: [place] に [living thing] います

公園に子供がいます。

Kouen ni kodomo ga imasu.

There are children in the park.

猫がいます。

Neko ga imasu.

There is a cat.

先生は教室にいます。

Sensei wa kyoushitsu ni imasu.

The teacher is in the classroom.

Tip: います = living (people, animals); あります = non-living. Choosing the wrong one is a classic beginner slip.**PRACTICE** 'There is a dog.' 犬が___。 → います**位置の言葉 (上・下・中…)** *position words***on, under, inside, next to...**

Position words describe where things are, using the pattern [noun] の [position] に. Common ones: 上 (up/above) 下 (under) 中 (inside) 前 (in front) 後ろ (behind) 隣 (next to) 近く (near)

07

Wanting & Liking

きぼう

Expressing what you want, like, and are good at.

In this chapter:

～がほしい

～たい

～が好き／嫌い

～が上手／下手

～がほしい ~ga hoshii

want [a thing]

To say you want an object, use [noun] が ほしい (ほしい is an i-adjective). 車がほしいです = I want a car. This is for wanting things, not actions.

Formation: [noun] + が + ほしいです

新しい車がほしいです。

Atarashii kuruma ga hoshii desu.

I want a new car.

時間がほしいです。

Jikan ga hoshii desu.

I want (more) time.

何がほしいですか。

Nani ga hoshii desu ka.

What do you want?

Tip: ほしい is for wanting THINGS. For wanting to DO something, use ～たい (next point).

PRACTICE 'I want water.' 水__ __ ほしいです。 → が

～たい ~tai

want to [do]

To say you want to DO something, drop ます from the verb and add たい. 食べます → 食べたい (want to eat). It conjugates like an i-adjective: 食べたいです, 食べたくないです。

Formation: [verb stem] + たいです

日本に行きたいです。

Nihon ni ikitai desu.

I want to go to Japan.

寿司を食べたいです。

Sushi wo tabetai desu.

I want to eat sushi.

何をしたいですか。

Nani wo shitai desu ka.

What do you want to do?

Tip: たい attaches to the verb stem (行き→行きたい) and then behaves like an i-adjective.

PRACTICE 'I want to see.' 見ます → 見__ __ です。 → たい

～が好き／嫌い ~ga suki / kirai

like / dislike

好き (like) and 嫌い (dislike) are na-adjectives, and what you like takes が. 犬が好きです = I like dogs. 大好き (love) and 大嫌い (hate) are also used.

～が上手／下手 *~ga jouzu / heta*

good at / bad at

上手 (skilled) and 下手 (unskilled) are na-adjectives describing ability, with が marking the skill. 料理が上手です = good at cooking. Be modest — Japanese speakers rarely call themselves 上手.

Formation: [noun] + が + 上手／下手です

彼は料理が上手です。

Kare wa ryouri ga jouzu desu.

He is good at cooking.

私は歌が下手です。

Watashi wa uta ga heta desu.

I am bad at singing.

日本語が上手ですね。

Nihongo ga jouzu desu ne.

Your Japanese is good, isn't it?

Tip: It's polite to call others 上手 but modest to call yourself 下手.

PRACTICE 'good at sport' スポーツ___上手です。 → が



08

The te-form & Everyday Patterns

てけい

One of the most useful verb forms — for requests, ongoing actions, — and connecting ideas.

WHERE YOUR JAPANESE JOURNEY BEGINS

In this chapter:

～てください

～ています

～てもいいです

～てください *~te kudasai*

please [do]

The te-form + ください makes a polite request: 'please do ____'. 待ってください = please wait. Forming the te-form takes practice (食べる→食べて, 行く→行って, 飲む→飲んで), but this pattern is everywhere.

Formation: [verb te-form] + ください

ちょっと待ってください。

Chotto matte kudasai.

Please wait a moment.

名前を書いてください。

Namae wo kaite kudasai.

Please write your name.

みてください。

Mite kudasai.

Please look.

Tip: The te-form has patterns worth memorising early – it unlocks many grammar points.

PRACTICE 'Please eat.' 食べて____。 → ください

～ています *~te imasu*

is [do]ing (ongoing)

te-form + います shows an action in progress right now, like English '-ing'. 食べています = am eating. It can also show ongoing states (住んでいます = I live [and continue to live]).

Formation: [verb te-form] + います

今、勉強しています。

Ima, benkyou shite imasu.

I am studying now.

雨が降っています。

Ame ga futte imasu.

It is raining.

東京に住んでいます。

Toukyou ni sunde imasu.

I live in Tokyo.

Tip: ています = right now (eating) OR an ongoing state (living somewhere).

PRACTICE 'I am reading.' 読んで____。 → います

～てもいいです *~te mo ii desu*

may / it's okay to [do]

te-form + もいいです grants permission: 'you may ____'. As a question, it asks for permission: 食べてもいいですか?

09

Connecting & Explaining

せつぞく

Words that link your ideas: because, but, and telling the time.

In this chapter:

～から (because)

～が (but)

時間の言い方 (～時／～分)

～ね／～よ

～から (because) ~kara

because / since

から after a reason means 'because'. The reason comes first, then から, then the result: 高いから買いません = because it's expensive, I won't buy it.

Formation: [reason] + から、[result]

寒いから、コートを着ます。

Samui kara, kotoo wo kimasu.

Because it's cold, I'll wear a coat.

時間がないから、行きません。

Jikan ga nai kara, ikimasen.

I won't go because I have no time.

好きだから、毎日食べます。

Suki dakara, mainichi tabemasu.

Because I like it, I eat it every day.

Tip: から comes AFTER the reason — the opposite position from English 'because'.

PRACTICE 'Because it's hot...' 暑い___、... → から

～が (but) ~ga

but / however

が at the end of a clause (not as a subject marker) means 'but'. 高いですが、買います = it's expensive, but I'll buy it. It gently joins two contrasting ideas.

Formation: [sentence 1] + が、[sentence 2]

高いですが、買います。

Takai desu ga, kaimasu.

It's expensive, but I'll buy it.

日本語は難しいですが、面白いです。

Nihongo wa muzukashii desu ga, omoshiroi desu.

Japanese is hard, but interesting.

行きたいですが、時間がありません。

Ikitai desu ga, jikan ga arimasen.

I want to go, but I have no time.

Tip: This が (but) follows a full clause, unlike subject-が which follows a noun.

PRACTICE 'It's cheap, but...' 安いです___、... → が

時間の言い方 (～時／～分) telling time

o'clock / minutes

Time uses 時 (o'clock) and 分 (minutes). 三時 = 3 o'clock, 十五分 = 15 minutes. Some readings change: 4時

〜ね／〜よ *~ne / ~yo*

right? / you know

These sentence-final particles add feeling. ね seeks agreement ('...isn't it?'): いい天気ですね. よ gives new info or emphasis ('you know'): 面白いですよ. They make speech sound natural and friendly.

Formation: [sentence] + ね／よ

いい天気ですね。

ii tenki desu ne.

Nice weather, isn't it?

この店は安いですよ。

Kono mise wa yasui desu yo.

This shop is cheap, you know.

そうですね。

Sou desu ne.

That's right / Let me see.

Tip: ね = seeking agreement (isn't it?); よ = informing/emphasising (I'm telling you).

PRACTICE Seek agreement: 'It's hot, isn't it?' 暑いです___. → ね





よくできました！

You've learned the building blocks!

With these 40 grammar points, you can form real Japanese sentences — ask questions, describe things, talk about the past, and connect your ideas. Review them often, use them in your own sentences, and they'll soon feel natural. Your Kanji handbook is the perfect next companion.

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